

Dear Barbara,

I hope you don't mind me reaching out directly. I have followed your work for some time, and I consider people like you mentors in helping me better understand homelessness ... not simply as an individual crisis, but as a housing and public-policy problem.

I am writing from Chico, California, because some of us advocating for our unhoused neighbors have reached a point where we could really use experienced guidance.

Since the 2018 Camp Fire devastated neighboring Paradise and displaced thousands of people into the Chico area, our community has struggled with an increasingly severe housing and homelessness crisis.

Years later, we are still dealing with the consequences ... but what troubles me most is how little affordable housing we actually produced when we had the opportunity.

During Chico's 2014-2022 RHNA cycle:

Low-Income housing goal: 643 units

Produced and planned: 194 units ... just 30.2% of the goal.

By comparison:

Above-Moderate housing goal: 1,638 units

Produced and planned: 3,498 units ... 213.6% of the goal.

So Chico demonstrated that it could produce housing ... just not nearly enough housing for the people with the least money.

At the same time, Chico has roughly a 7.9% overall housing vacancy rate.

That contradiction matters.

We can have thousands of vacant housing units and still have a housing crisis because vacancy does not mean affordability. Housing can exist physically while remaining completely inaccessible financially to the people who need it most.

Meanwhile, the City has spent millions of dollars managing homelessness through shelters, emergency programs, enforcement, cleanups, policing, and other services.

Chico remains under a formally declared Shelter Crisis and is currently operating under the federal Warren v. City of Chico settlement.

That settlement is approaching its expiration.

Now, just weeks before our November City Council election, the Council is considering changes to Chico's camping and public-space ordinances in anticipation of Warren ending. Among the proposed changes are expanded penalties for violations of the City's camping laws, including the possibility of misdemeanor citations in addition to infractions.

That deeply concerns me.

My fear is that Chico is preparing to increase the criminalization of homelessness without first creating the housing necessary to end homelessness.

The City has also concentrated its authorized shelter response among a small number of organizations. Truly low-barrier alternatives remain extremely limited.

People can be denied admission or discharged from existing shelter programs under their rules ... yet if someone cannot access those programs, there are very few lawful alternatives left to them.

At the same time, other organizations and community members have proposed alternative approaches ... including projects that would require little or no taxpayer funding ... only to encounter resistance, delays, or rejection from the City.

I am not suggesting that every shelter provider is doing something wrong.

What concerns me is the larger system.

We seem to have built a substantial infrastructure for managing homelessness while failing to build housing affordable to the people most likely to become homeless.

Your recent interview struck me particularly hard when you said:

"Homelessness is a choice, but it's the policy choice that we've made. It's not the choice of any of the individuals."

And:

"We can't arrest our way out of poverty."

Those statements describe exactly what I fear Chico is about to forget.

I have also submitted a housing-related complaint to the California Attorney General's Housing Justice Team asking the State to examine Chico's record regarding affordable housing, homelessness policy, public spending, and barriers encountered by alternative housing and shelter proposals.

I don't know where that effort will lead ... but I felt that someone outside our local political system needed to look at the larger picture.

Barbara, I don't pretend to be a housing-policy professional.

I am simply a Chico resident who has experienced homelessness myself and has spent a great deal of time trying to understand why our community continues to spend so much money responding to homelessness while producing so little housing for the people most at risk of becoming homeless.

What I am asking for is guidance.

If you were standing where we are standing ... what would you be asking our City Council right now?

What should we be documenting?

What data should we insist upon?

What should advocates be saying publicly as the Warren agreement approaches its expiration?

How should we respond when enforcement is presented as a solution to a problem fundamentally rooted in the lack of affordable housing?

And is there anything you ... or someone you would recommend ... might be able to do to help us navigate this moment?

Even a few thoughts, resources, examples from other communities, or suggestions about whom we should contact would mean a great deal to us.

I keep coming back to something else from your work ...

We need to stop managing homelessness and start ending it.

That is what I want for Chico.

And if your travels ever bring you to Northern California, I would also be honored to invite you to visit Chico.

It really is a beautiful community ... and I think seeing both what we love about this town and the challenges we are struggling with would provide a perspective that statistics alone cannot.

I would be happy to show you around, introduce you to people doing this work locally, and let you hear directly from people with lived experience.

Thank you for taking the time to read this ... and thank you for the many years you have spent doing this work.

Warmly,

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